

Delayed LEGISLATION

Over 50 Bills are pending in the Government's 'In' tray

The Civil Liability for Nuclear Damages, 2010 Was tipped to be introduced in the Budget Session but had to be dropped due to opposition from its allies

Women's Reservation Bill, 2008 Passed by Rajya Sabha in March 2010 but not yet introduced in Lok Sabha

National Commission for Minority Educational Institutes, 2009 The Standing Committee report was given on November 25, 2009, but it is yet to make it to Parliament

Land Acquisition (Amendment) Bill 2010 To amend the Land Acquisition Act of 1894

Communal Violence Prevention and Control and Rehabilitation of Victims Bill 2005 The Law Ministry is making changes sought by Sonia Gandhi

Representation of People Amendment Bill, 2006 Standing Committee Report on August 4, 2006

Food Security Bill 2010 Still at drafting stage. Sonia has rejected the first draft.

The Foreign Educational Institutions Regulation of Entry and Operations Bill, 2010 The Cabinet has passed it but the Government is worried that it will be defeated

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ing the right to privacy, and will uphold the rights of the individual citizens enshrined in the Constitution of India."

What was also worrying the Government was the rather unusual coming together of the Left and the Right along with Mulayam and Lalu, triggering nightmares that reminded Congressmen of the 1989 formation where a Lohiaite group was propped up by the Left and the Right. The sister act of Sushma Swaraj and Brinda Karat hugging sent the crisis managers back to their calculators to do the math.

Salvation came by accident instead of some great pre-planned strategy. By pushing for the Women's Reservation Bill, the Congress unwittingly created an ideological divide in this coalition of unnatural allies. Both Mulayam and Lalu had made it clear that they did not accept the Bill in its present form and instead wanted a quota within a quota. At that time, a buoyant Sonia had joked that the Government may soon bring in a bill for men's reservation too. Jokes aside, she did succeed in creating some reservations within the Opposition. Angry that the BJP and the Left had deserted them on the Women's

Reservations Bill, the Yadav duo decided to chart their own course. "Even if we had voted along with the BJP, the Government would not have fallen," Lalu told reporters somewhat ruefully on the steps of Parliament on his way out. The fact is that Lalu and the Left couldn't even agree on where to protest about rising prices. Lalu insisted on the backdrop of Mahatma Gandhi statue, knowing well that the Marxists would be allergic to the idea.

On such fragile egos was based the heavy mantle of Opposition unity. Another reason why both Mulayam and Lalu were quick to distance themselves from the BJP was simple politics. They watched in horror Mayawati's migration from anti-Congress to pro-Congress position under the pretext of keeping communal forces at bay. Worried that Mayawati was playing the secular card against them, the Yadav duo too quickly distanced themselves from the saffron forces. As Mulayam told Lalu, he was still to recover from the taint of being associated with Kalyan Singh, the former BJP chief minister of Uttar Pradesh. Suddenly the Congress had a problem of plenty as it cruised to a

IT HAS BEEN A
rather busy fortnight for
the Government. Barely
had Manmohan Singh
recovered from the IPL
scandal than came
phone tapping allega-
tions and cut motions.